husband Boney, industrialists and models. ‘All my friends, they will do anything for me,’ he said, his body oozing the latest perfume.

The Amar Singh culture of wheeling and dealing came to haunt the SP. Mulayam Singh had always been ‘Netaji’ to his colleagues, a political and real-life wrestler, born in a small village, who had started life as a schoolteacher. Amar Singh gave him a taste of the high life and he didn’t want to let go. *‘Party badal gayi, Netaji badal gaye, sabko paise ki lalach ho gayi’* (The party changed, Mulayam changed, everyone wanted to make money), said a veteran SP MP.

But the real decline in the SP’s work culture was not catalysed by Amar Singh but by Mulayam’s own family. Almost every relative was given a position within the party structure. Akhilesh’s wife was an MP, an uncle was a minister, another uncle was a Rajya Sabha MP. *‘Samajwaad parivarwaad ban gaya!’* (Socialism has become family raj), is how a senior UP journalist described it to me.

Family power can breed arrogance. No one was more arrogant than Shivpal Yadav, Mulayam’s younger brother. The rough-talking Shivpal had acquired notoriety as a PWD minister who apparently had a ‘rate card’ for handing over government contracts. ‘You want any work done in UP, you need to go to Shivpalji,’ is what a UP bureaucrat told me once.

It was this work culture, then, that Akhilesh was inheriting, one which he needed to discard to be successful. I remember asking Akhilesh on the campaign trail how he would deal with his uncles once he became chief minister. *‘Koi problem nahi hoga, hum saath kaam karenge!’* (No problem, we will all work together.)

His confidence was horribly misplaced. When the government came to power, the old order took over. Akhilesh for them was a *bachcha* (kid). UP’s thriving transfer-posting business was back, as was a common practice by which Yadavs were given preference in government jobs. ‘If you are a Yadav, you could get a police station of your choice,’ is what a senior UP police officer told me.

Also marking a return was UP’s ‘goonda raj’ in sharp contrast to Mayawati’s tough-on-law-and-order image. Our office was in Noida in UP.